Stefan Herytash

sherytash.github.io

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Thyra Uth Thomsen, Head of Department, and the assessment committee
Department of Marketing
Copenhagen Business School
Solbjerg Plads 3
2000 Frederiksberg, Denmark

Application for the Tenure Track Assistant Professorship in Digital Marketing

Dear Thyra Uth Thomsen and members of the assessment committee,

I am applying for this position as an Assistant Professor at WU Vienna. I trained in mathematics at TU Wien and the University of Zurich, and took my PhD in Management, summa cum laude, at the Institute for Market-Based Management of LMU Munich, with a thesis on simulating human decision-making with large language models.

A firm in digital marketing can now pre-test an ad, a landing page, an offer or a price on answers that a language model writes in seconds. A pre-test that once needed a consumer panel costs almost nothing. My research asks when such simulated consumers can be trusted, and how platforms and journals certify quality once evidence is this cheap. Within marketing my core area is consumer behaviour: each of my simulation studies asks whether a model reproduces how consumers respond to a marketing stimulus.

My solo paper *When and How to Integrate AI Simulations into Behavioral Experimentation* (Revise & Resubmit at International Journal of Research in Marketing) gives that answer for behavioural experiments. I simulate 70 treatment effects from 30 published marketing studies at the level of the instrument: each synthetic respondent completes the original questionnaire in one randomized condition. Simulated and human effects correlate at $r = .73$, but the simulations come out at about two-fifths of the human magnitudes. They can rank ideas before a test is run; they cannot yet price them. At CBS this work would sit next to Felix Eggers' studies of language-model valuations and design priors for choice experiments. His human choice panels and my benchmark could together estimate how much correction synthetic data needs before it can inform a decision.

My second measurement line is econometric and concerns pricing and promotion. In a many-analyst study forthcoming in the *International Journal of Research in Marketing*, I was one of 156 analyst teams that estimated brand price elasticities from the same household panel data. The team averages range from −7.3 to +3.1, and choices on time aggregation, fixed effects, time controls and marketing-mix covariates explain the largest share of that spread. Promotion planning rests on these elasticities, which ties the work to the Digital Marketing Research Cluster's projects on online promotions and customer value. At LMU I also worked on predicting engagement with social media ads using machine learning.

Digital platforms certify sellers and wages through thresholds: a badge above a rating, a salary band above a number of reports. This is where my certification work turns digital. kununu, the largest employer-review and salary platform in the German-speaking labour market, shows a salary band only once enough employees have reported one. Since August I have been negotiating a multi-year data partnership with kununu, and the paper I am preparing estimates what that threshold does to applicant flows. Airbnb, whose data I have worked on at LMU, certifies hosts in the same way. Its Superhost badge requires an average rating of at least 4.8 and thresholds on response, cancellations and stays. The public Inside Airbnb snapshots record both the rating and the badge; in a project I plan, a regression discontinuity at the thresholds would separate the badge from the quality it is meant to signal. Antonia Erz has shown that two-sided review systems change how customers behave toward suppliers; both platforms are two-sided markets of that kind. The same question runs through *After the Fax Machine Burns* (Submitted to Management Science as a Discussion Paper), on what a journal should certify when manuscripts cost almost nothing to

write, and *Threshold Migration to the Patient* (Accepted at ANZAM 2026), which follows a consumer wearable into a profession's gate.

CBS is where I want to do this work. The department ranks among Europe's top five business schools for publications in leading marketing journals, and its five research clusters cover the areas this position welcomes, with the Digital Marketing Research Cluster at the centre of mine. CogLab and the experiments.cbs.dk participant pool would let me run the simulated and the human version of the same study side by side on Danish samples; so far my benchmark compares simulations with published results. Constant Pieters' work on replication and measurement validity sets the test that simulated respondents still have to pass, and I would like to build that audit with him. CBS's strategic initiative Accelerating AI and Digitalisation fits the simulation work, and the department's Responsible Marketing & Societal impact fits the certification work: a badge or a salary band is a public claim about quality that consumers and workers rely on. The department's mix of research faculty and about 60 practice lecturers is the link to firms that both lines need, and I would like to take an active part in its life.

Teaching is where I can contribute from the first semester. At WU I designed *Agentic AI in Strategy & Innovation*, in which students build and evaluate working agents; 95 % of the students recommend it. This term I run the *Business Project* of WU's master's programme with Vienna Airport as corporate partner. At LMU Munich I taught the *Seminar on AI in Marketing* in 2024 and 2025 and the exercise sessions of *Marketing Management*, and at EM Lyon the course *Analyzing Markets*. At CBS I would offer a master's elective on generative AI as a marketing research method, in which students test simulated respondents against human data and build agentic analysis workflows. It would sit one level above the applied AI courses in the bachelor's programmes and the GMA summer school, and next to Brand Analytics in the EMF.

I will relocate to Copenhagen and be present in the department. I will learn Danish, which I am eager to do. I will teach general marketing at bachelor's level again, as I did at LMU and EM Lyon, besides the master's elective. I would also like to teach executives: at WU I teach the AI sessions of the *Vienna Innovation Program*, an executive-level programme for North American Master of Business Administration students. I will explain what my research means for society, both to the public and to CBS's partners in business: in talks for practitioners, through the open-source SimuLabs engine behind my simulation papers, and through the interactive figures of my papers on my website.

At WU I serve on the appointment committee for the Full Professor of Strategic Management and review for the Schmalenbach Journal of Business Research and four conferences; at CBS I will take on department and CBS-wide tasks. At LMU I raised over €100,000 in research funding for the institute from industry partners, and as a freelance consultant I ran market research and analytics for clients including Bayer and Allianz. In Denmark I would apply first to the Independent Research Fund Denmark's thematic call Research on Artificial Intelligence, with a senior colleague from the department.

I can start on 1 September 2027. From January to March 2027 I am a Visiting Scholar at the Scandinavian Consortium for Organizational Research at Stanford. The application documents and a statement of how my work fits the department are at `https://sherytash.github.io/for/cbs/`.

Sincerely,

Stefan Herytash